

Case Study: Building a Founder-Led CRM for Early-Stage Startups

Problem Statement

In early-stage startups (0–20 employees), sales are usually handled directly by the founder.

Most founders:

- Close deals via WhatsApp, email, LinkedIn DMs, calls
- Track leads in Notion, Google Sheets, or memory
- Forget follow-ups
- Overestimate pipeline health
- Have no clear visibility into deal stages

Existing CRM tools like Salesforce, HubSpot, or Zoho feel:

- Too heavy
- Too enterprise-focused
- Too setup-intensive
- Time-consuming to maintain

As a result:

- 30–40% of warm leads never receive structured follow-up
 - Deal tracking is inconsistent
 - Revenue forecasting is unreliable
 - Founders operate in reactive mode
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Current Reality

A typical early-stage founder:

- Has 50–150 active conversations at a time
- Uses 4–6 communication channels
- Spends 70% of time closing, not updating systems
- Forgets to log calls or notes
- Tracks follow-ups manually

Pain increases when:

- Startup starts scaling
 - Hiring first salesperson
 - Investors ask for pipeline clarity
 - Revenue targets increase
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The Core Problem

Traditional CRM systems are not designed for founder-led, high-speed, multi-channel early sales.

Founders need:

- Zero-friction tracking
- Automatic capture of conversations
- Clear next-action reminders
- Lightweight pipeline visibility

Without becoming full-time CRM managers.

Deliverables- (What you must Submit)

Your submission must include:

1. A clear problem definition
2. Current tool problems and workflows
3. Identification of the core gap
4. Defined primary user persona (founders)
5. Key metrics to improve (e.g., No. of steps to take an action, tools used)
6. Proposed product concept
7. One bold “moonshot” idea
8. 2–3 practical supporting features
9. High-level product flow
10. MVP scope definition
11. Trade-offs and limitations
12. A working prototype

Scoring Paradigm-

- 1) Problem Space- 30 points
- 2) Solution Space- 30 points
- 3) Prototype- 30 points
- 4) Presentation- 10 points

